DoD Combined Technical/Risk Rating Method

Color Rating	Adjectival Rating	Description
Blue	Outstanding	Proposal indicates an exceptional approach and understanding of the requirements and contains multiple strengths, and risk of unsuccessful performance is low.
Purple	Good	Proposal indicates a thorough approach and understanding of the requirements and contains at least one strength, and risk of unsuccessful performance is low to moderate.
Green	Acceptable	Proposal meets requirements and indicates an adequate approach and understanding of the requirements, and risk of unsuccessful performance is no worse than moderate.
Yellow	Marginal	Proposal has not demonstrated an adequate approach and understanding of the requirements, and/or risk of unsuccessful performance is high.
Red	Unacceptable	Proposal does not meet requirements of the solicitation, and thus, contains one or more deficiencies, and/or risk of unsuccessful performance is unacceptable. Proposal is unawardable.

Department of Defense Source Selection Procedures Apr 01 2016

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DoD Technical Rating Method

Color Rating	Adjectival Rating	Description
Blue	Outstanding	Proposal indicates an exceptional approach and understanding of the requirements and contains multiple strengths.
Purple	Good	Proposal indicates a thorough approach and understanding of the requirements and contains at least one strength.
Green	Acceptable	Proposal indicates an adequate approach and understanding of the requirements.
Yellow	Marginal	Proposal has not demonstrated an adequate approach and understanding of the requirements.
Red	Unacceptable	Proposal does not meet requirements of the solicitation and, thus, contains one or more deficiencies and is unawardable.

Department of Defense Source Selection Procedures Apr 01 2016

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DoD Technical Risk Rating Method

Adjectival Rating	Description
Low	Proposal may contain weakness(es) which have little potential to cause disruption of schedule, increased cost or degradation of performance. Normal contractor effort and normal Government monitoring will likely be able to overcome any difficulties.
Moderate	Proposal contains a significant weakness or combination of weaknesses which may potentially cause disruption of schedule, increased cost or degradation of performance. Special contractor emphasis and close Government monitoring will likely be able to overcome difficulties.
High	Proposal contains a significant weakness or combination of weaknesses which is likely to cause significant disruption of schedule, increased cost or degradation of performance. Is unlikely to overcome any difficulties, even with special contractor emphasis and close Government monitoring.
Unacceptable	Proposal contains a material failure or a combination of significant weaknesses that increases the risk of unsuccessful performance to an unacceptable level.

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DoD Past Performance Relevancy Rating Method

Adjectival Rating	Description
Very Relevant	Present/past performance effort involved essentially the same scope and magnitude of effort and complexities this solicitation requires.
Relevant	Present/past performance effort involved similar scope and magnitude of effort and complexities this solicitation requires.
Somewhat Relevant	Present/past performance effort involved some of the scope and magnitude of effort and complexities this solicitation requires.
Not Relevant	Present/past performance effort involved little or none of the scope and magnitude of effort and complexities this solicitation requires.

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DoD Performance Confidence Assessments Rating Method

Adjectival Rating	Description
Substantial Confidence	Based on the offeror's recent/relevant performance record, the Government has a high expectation that the offeror will successfully perform the required effort.
Satisfactory Confidence	Based on the offeror's recent/relevant performance record, the Government has a reasonable expectation that the offeror will successfully perform the required effort.
Neutral Confidence	No recent/relevant performance record is available or the offeror's performance record is so sparse that no meaningful confidence assessment rating can be reasonably assigned. The offeror may not be evaluated favorably or unfavorably on the factor of past performance.
Limited Confidence	Based on the offeror's recent/relevant performance record, the Government has a low expectation that the offeror will successfully perform the required effort.
No Confidence	Based on the offeror's recent/relevant performance record, the Government has no expectation that the offeror will be able to successfully perform the required effort.

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Strengths and Weaknesses

- ***Strength*** is an aspect of an offeror's proposal that has merit or exceeds specified performance or capability requirements in a way that will be advantageous to the Government during contract performance.
- ***Weakness*** means a flaw in the proposal that increases the risk of unsuccessful contract performance. See FAR 15.001.
- ***Significant Weakness*** in the proposal is a flaw that appreciably increases the risk of unsuccessful contract performance. See FAR 15.001.

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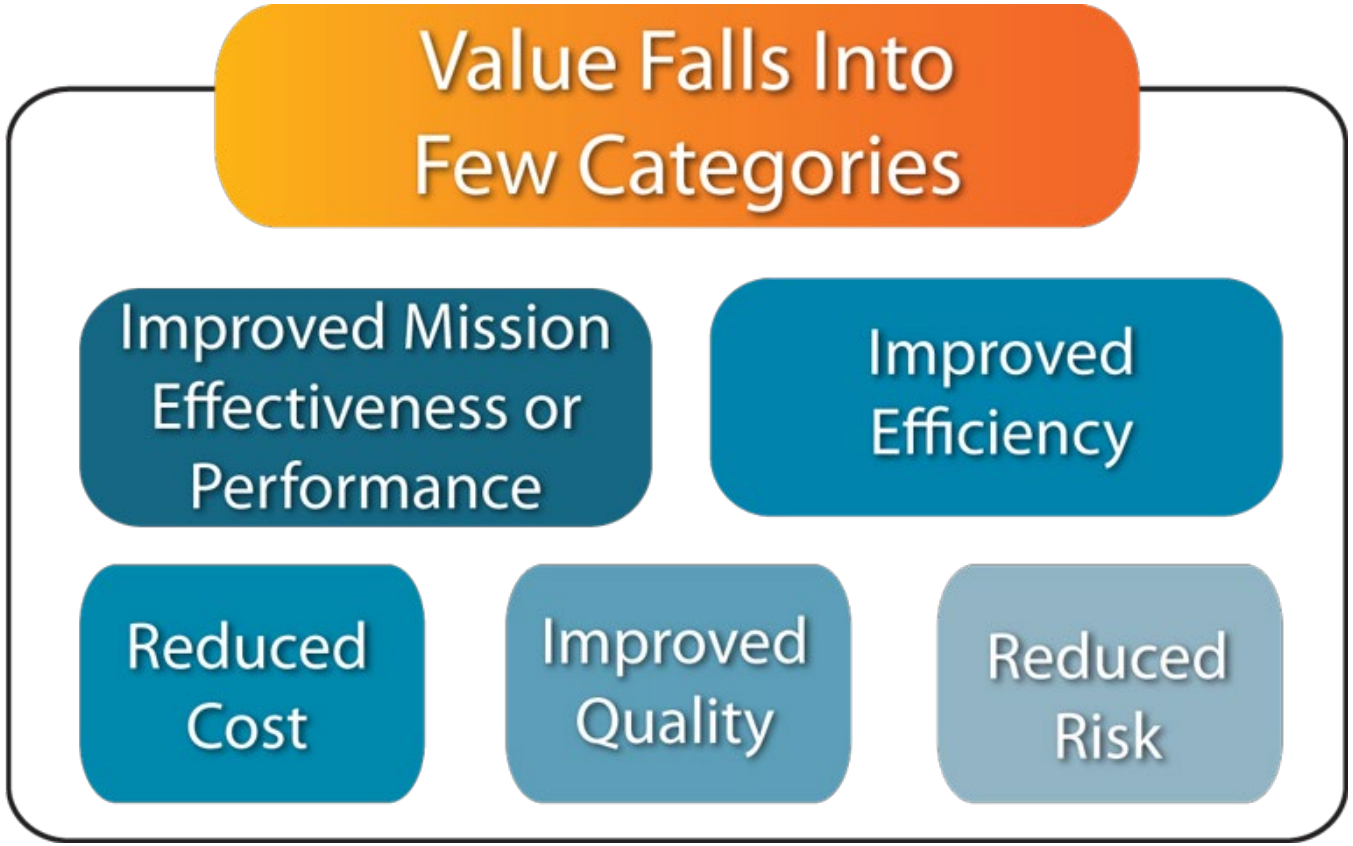
The Value Box



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Focus on Solution Features, Benefits, and Discriminators to Score Blue in Your Section

Feature: A significant attribute or characteristic of your proposed solution.

Benefit: What that feature delivers that has value to the customer.

Strength: An aspect of an offeror's proposal that has merit or exceeds specified performance or capability requirements in a way that will be advantageous to the Government during contract performance.

Discriminator: A solution feature that solves an issue important to the Customer (benefit) that is unique to you.

Proof: Facts and data supporting claims.

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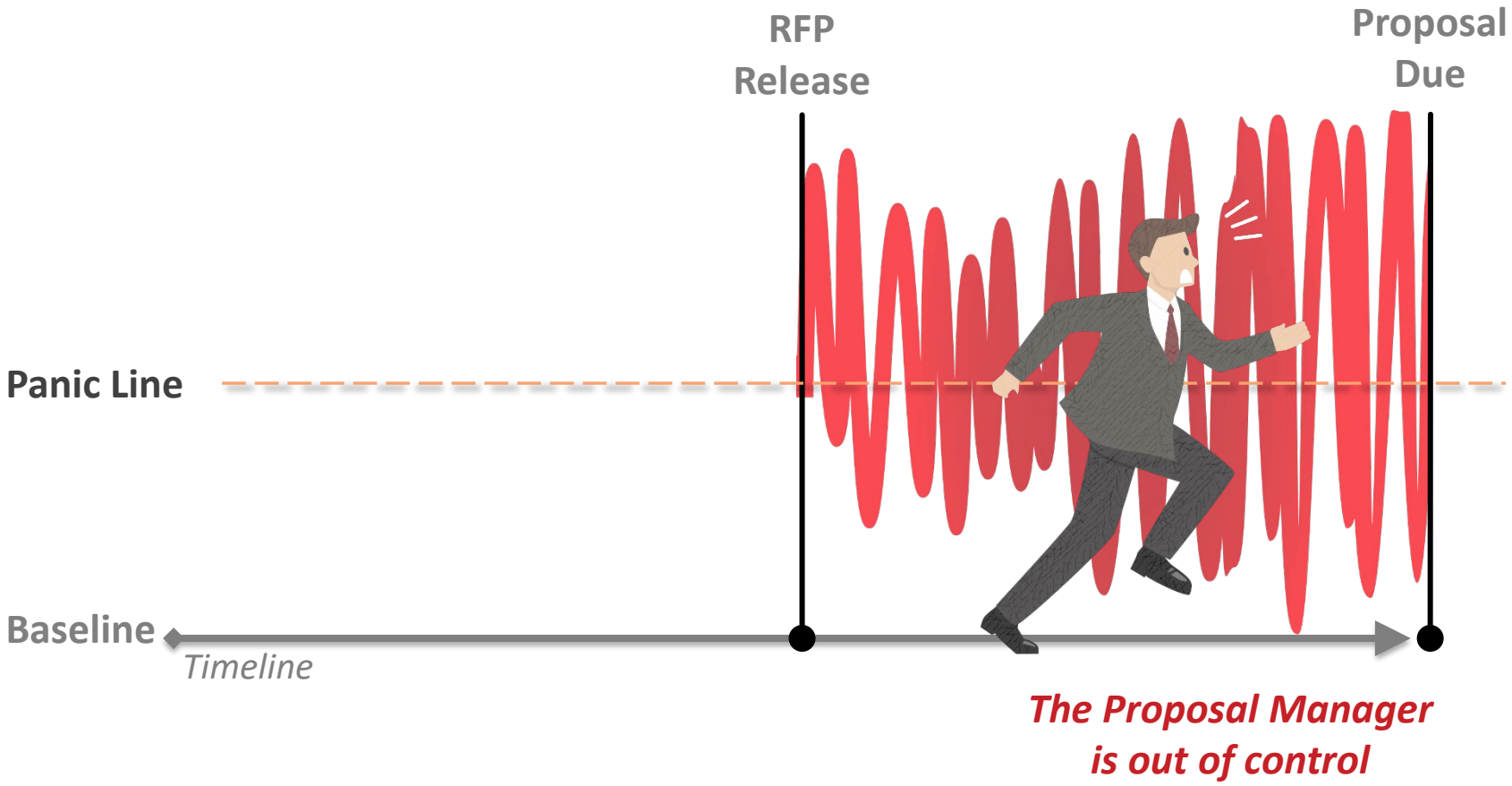
Plotting the EKG of a Typical Proposal Manager



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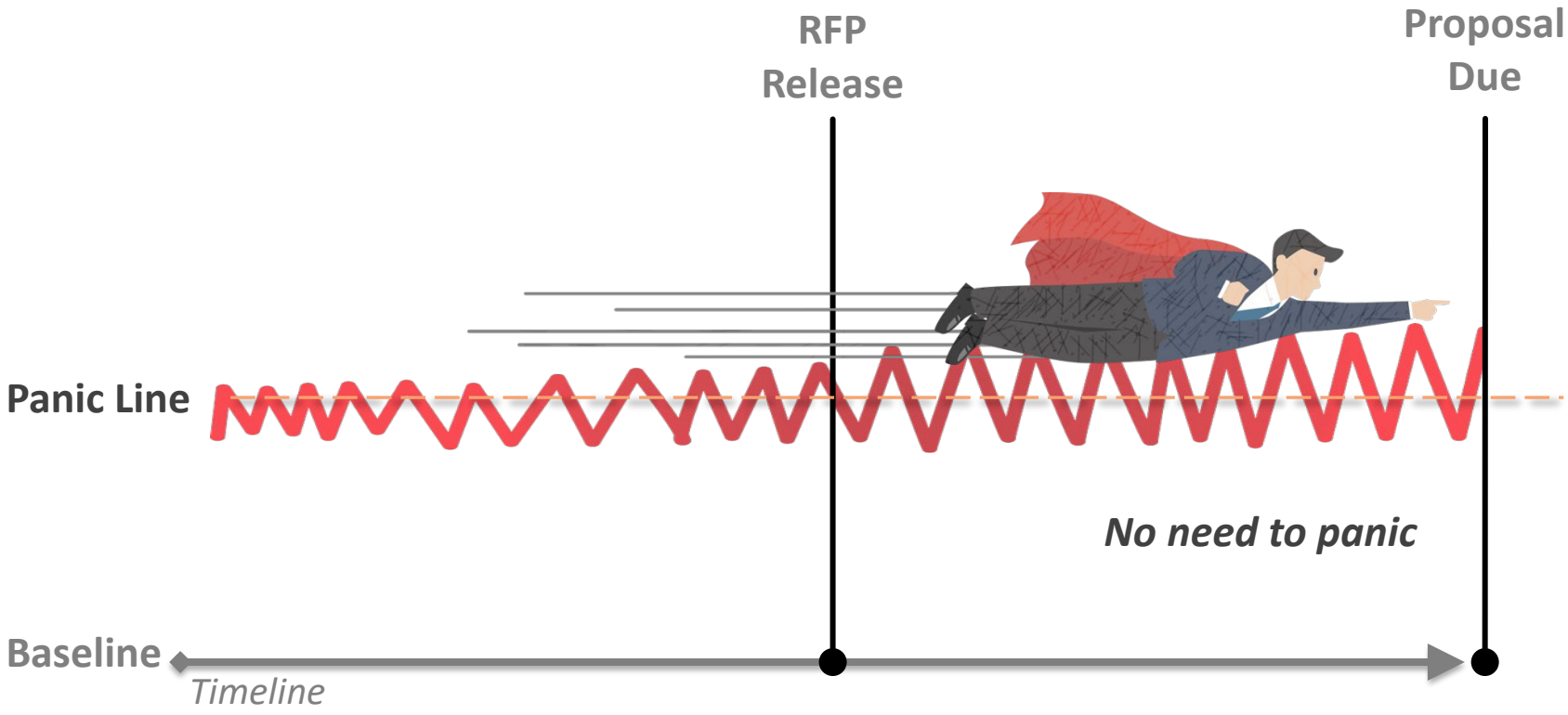
Proposal Manager's EKG with Planning



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Main Tasks as a Proposal Manager

PRIMARY RESPONSIBILITIES

- Understand the capture strategy, including:
  - Competitors
  - Customer needs
  - Solution and benefits
- Form a proposal team—define roles
- Thoroughly assess RFP/RFI (solicitation)
- Create and manage a compliance and response matrix
- Create and manage a proposal schedule
- Facilitate daily status meetings
- Interface with sales/capture lead
- Conduct and execute proposal reviews
- Manage storyboard/mockup process
- Create writers' packages and make assignments

SECONDARY RESPONSIBILITIES

- Train proposal contributors on best practices and expectations
- Assist writers with content development
- Collaborate on proposal graphics
- Ensure price, management, and technical volumes are consistent
- Keep leadership well-informed
- Prepare for orals or other follow-on activities

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Three Steps for Proposal Strategy Development

01

Assess changes to competitive position which may have occurred since the last update of the capture plan

02

Update a bidder comparison chart to reflect new competitive situations

03

Develop proposal and volume strategies that are extensions of capture strategy

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Eric’s Kickoff Time Rule

- Schedule kickoff when 10% of the days allowed for delivery have passed
  - 30 days……day 3
  - 45 days……day 4 or 5
  - 90 days……day 8 or 9
  - 2 weeks……..day 2
  - 10 days……day 2

- Kickoff when you are read! Don’t kickoff before you are ready!

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Planning and Executing a Pink Team Review

Organizer:	Proposal Manager
Team Members	• Independent, respected Pink Team leader • Line managers • Subcontractor executives • Business development managers • Subject matter experts
Other Attendees	• Capture manager • Program manager
Possible Approaches	• Walking the wall • Sequential presentation • Virtual review of planning documents • Independent compliance verification

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Planning and Executing a Red Team Review

Organizer:	Proposal Manager Red Team preparation leader	
Possible Team Members	• Independent Red Team leader • Executives • Teammate executives	• Operations personnel • Subject matter experts • Customer experts • Pink Team members
Other Attendees	• Capture manager	• Red Team preparation task lead
Possible Approaches	• Mirror of customer's evaluation process • Detailed in-briefing • Vertical section reviews • Horizontal reviews • Independent compliance check	• Gadfly review • Collaborative discussions • Consolidated recommendations • Proposal team debriefing • Core team recovery

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Past Performance vs. Relevant Experience

Past Performance

1. Name the contract title
2. State project goals met
   On time, On budget, Quality, Service Level Agreements
3. Identify outcomes
   Performance metrics

Relevant Experience

Include examples with claims

Identify similar projects

Reference similar and relevant stories

Skills and capability to carry out solution

RelEx = *What + Where have we done work that is similar to the proposed effort?*

Past Perf = *What + Where + How well did we do it?*

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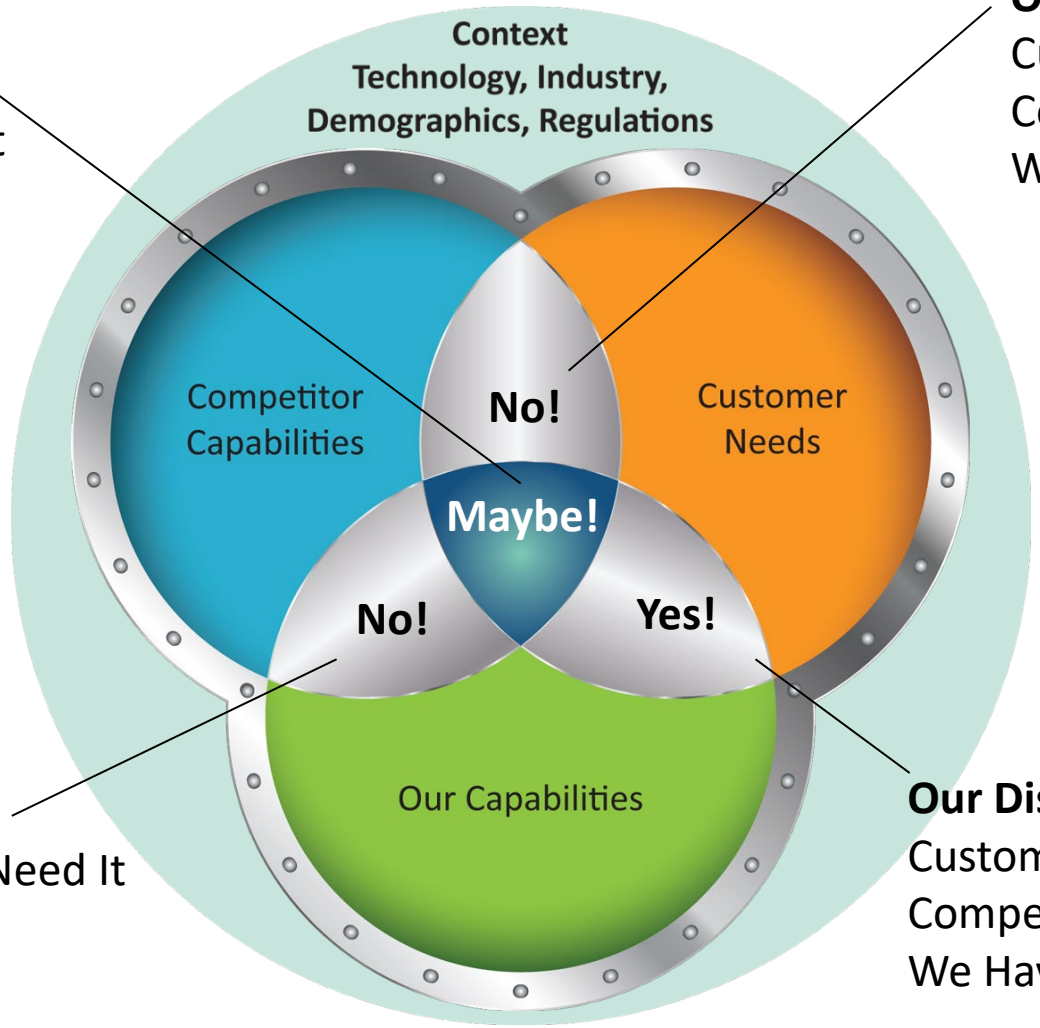
Discriminators

Neutral Position
Customer Needs It
Competitor Has It
We Have It

Our Weakness
Customer Needs It
Competitor Has It
We Don't Have It



Irrelevant Position
Customer Doesn't Need It
Competitor Has It
We Have It

Our Discriminators
Customer Needs It
Competitor Doesn't Have It
We Have It

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Theme Statements Link Benefits to Features

Feature

Box 1 – Summary

Benefit

The Vibrant **CRM system** provides long-term support of your objectives. Outdoor Sports Global will **reduce the cost** of both sales tracking and lead generation campaigns by selecting Vibrant as its partner.

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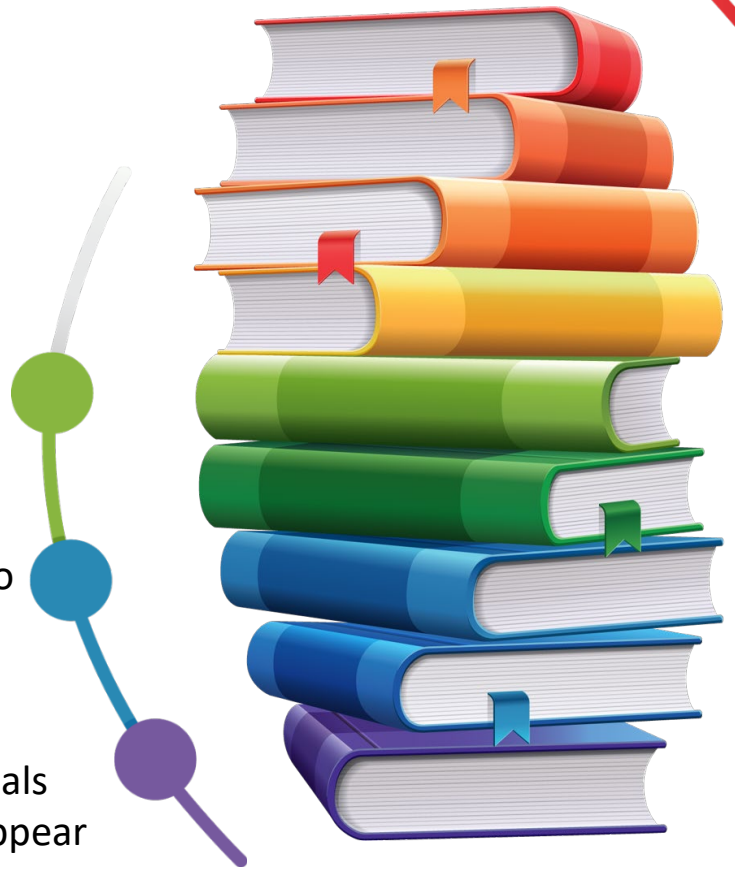
Guidelines for Visuals in Text



- Minimize text in visuals
- Understandable < 10 seconds
- Are relevant, not just decorative
- Orient visuals vertically
- Integrate visuals into the text
- Introduce visuals before they appear

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Use Focus Boxes at Section Beginnings to Highlight Main Points

The Navy achieves a low-risk design/build solution that focuses on ease of use and low maintenance through SBI's 20 years of experience building 2,100 military and paramilitary patrol craft.

- Successfully delivered the Navy MK VI (9 boats), USCG RB-S/HS (550 boats), CB-OTH (67 boats), RPB (36 boats), RCB (9 boats)
- Extensive experience in systems integration (ballistics, Tactical Communication and Navigation (TCAN), propulsion)
- Platforms delivered with NECC (9-RCB, 9-MK VI, 36-SURC/RPB, 45-25TT MSF)

Help evaluators to score you "blue:"

- Make your response <u>EASY TO FIND</u>.
- Make your response <u>EASY TO SCORE</u> favorably.
- Make your response <u>EASY TO COPY & PASTE</u> into evaluators' Power Point slides.

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Use Callout Boxes to Highlight Key Points

- Placed throughout the section to draw the evaluator's attention
- May include:
  - Key points
  - Testimonials
  - Past performance examples
  - Proof statements in support of your message

"SBI's performance to date has been exceptional…
I highly recommend them for future work within the U.S. Government."

--Chief Randhousen,
Installation Support Division,
Tooele Army Depot

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Using Logos: Protecting the Brand

- When possible, the logo should be reproduced in color
- Do not use the logo in colors other than the logo's colors
- Do not expand or compress the logo
- Do not alter the logo in any way

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Action Caption Guidelines

Page 116

- Draw the conclusion for the reader
- Are full sentences
- Contain three parts:
  1-Figure number, 2-title,
  3-supporting text
- Link benefits to features
- Are succinct
- Allow graphic to stand alone
- Are below the graphic

Figure 3-2. Calls Per Hour. *Team productivity is lower at the end of the week due to reduced demand for team services heading into the weekend.*

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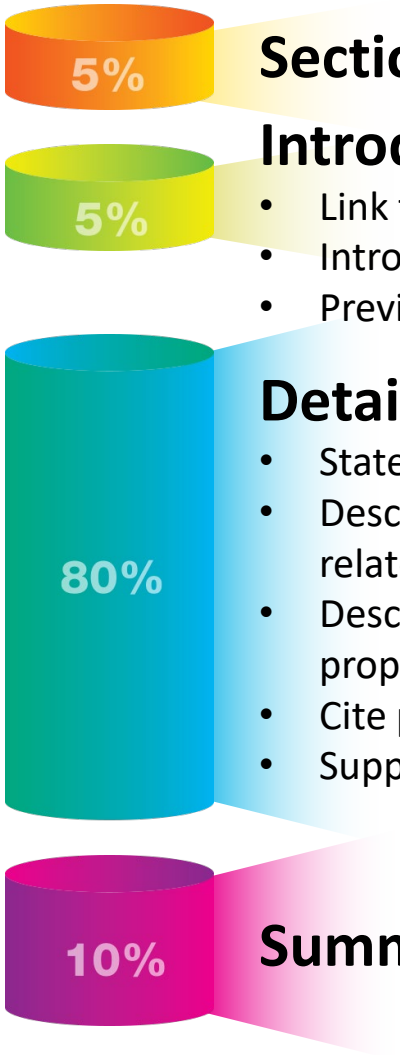
Allocate Space for Section Elements



Section title

Introduction

- Link to customer requirement or need
- Introduce solution and capability with key benefits and features
- Preview if more than three subordinate topics

Details of response

- State requirement/issue/hot button
- Describe benefits provided with emphasis on any discriminators related to the solution
- Describe the solution / features offered including what is proposed and how it will be provided
- Cite proof of your ability to deliver the solution with minimal risk
- Support the response with a visual and action caption

Summary

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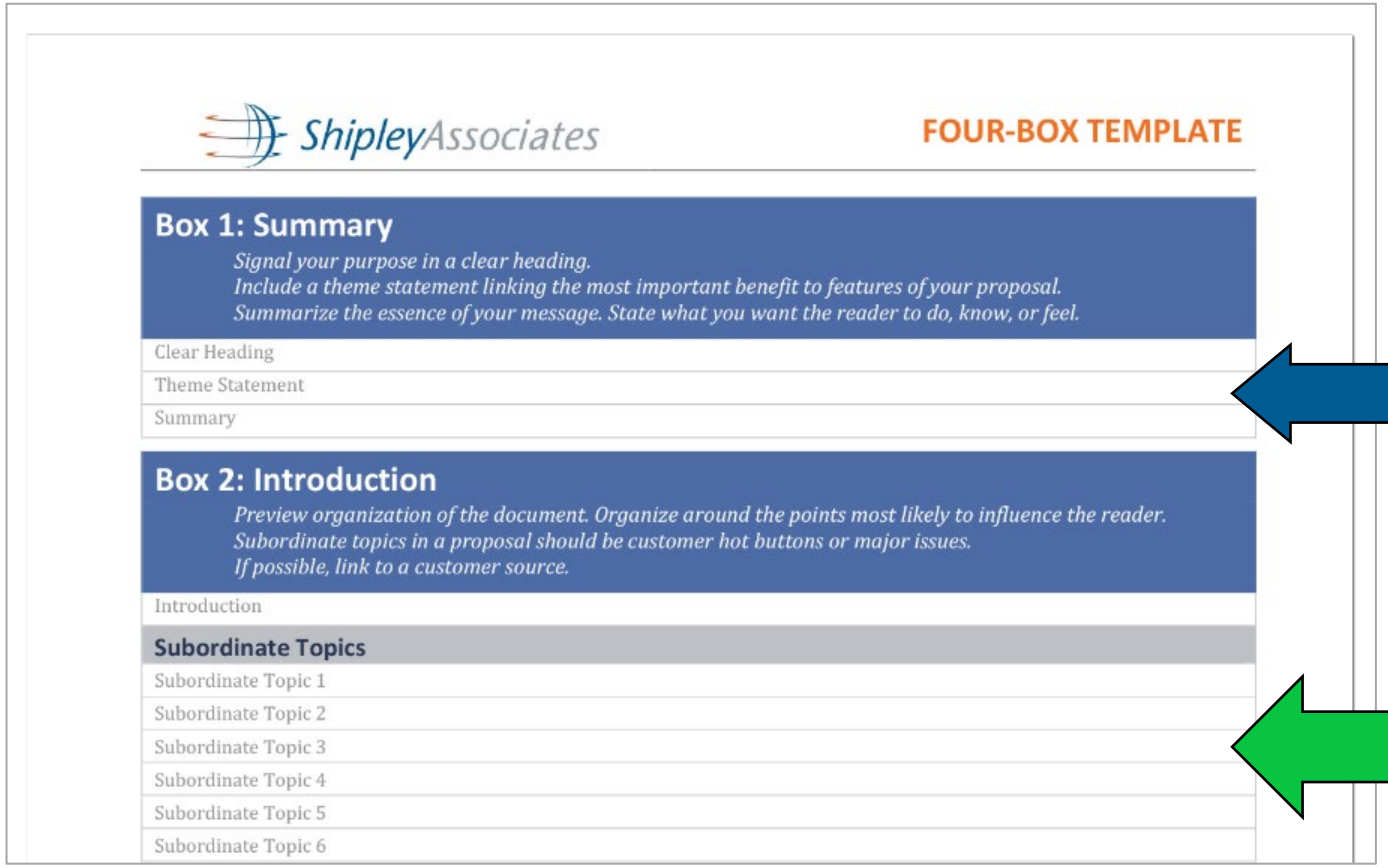
Four-Box Template Simplifies Organization



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FOUR-BOX TEMPLATE

Box 1: Summary

Signal your purpose in a clear heading.
Include a theme statement linking the most important benefit to features of your proposal.
Summarize the essence of your message. State what you want the reader to do, know, or feel.

Clear Heading
Theme Statement
Summary

Box 2: Introduction

Preview organization of the document. Organize around the points most likely to influence the reader.
Subordinate topics in a proposal should be customer hot buttons or major issues.
If possible, link to a customer source.

Introduction

Subordinate Topics

Subordinate Topic 1
Subordinate Topic 2
Subordinate Topic 3
Subordinate Topic 4
Subordinate Topic 5
Subordinate Topic 6

Main heading
Theme statement
Strategic direction: link your offer to their strategic direction

Roadmap: here's what we're going to tell you…
A Major issue 1
B Major issue 2
etc.

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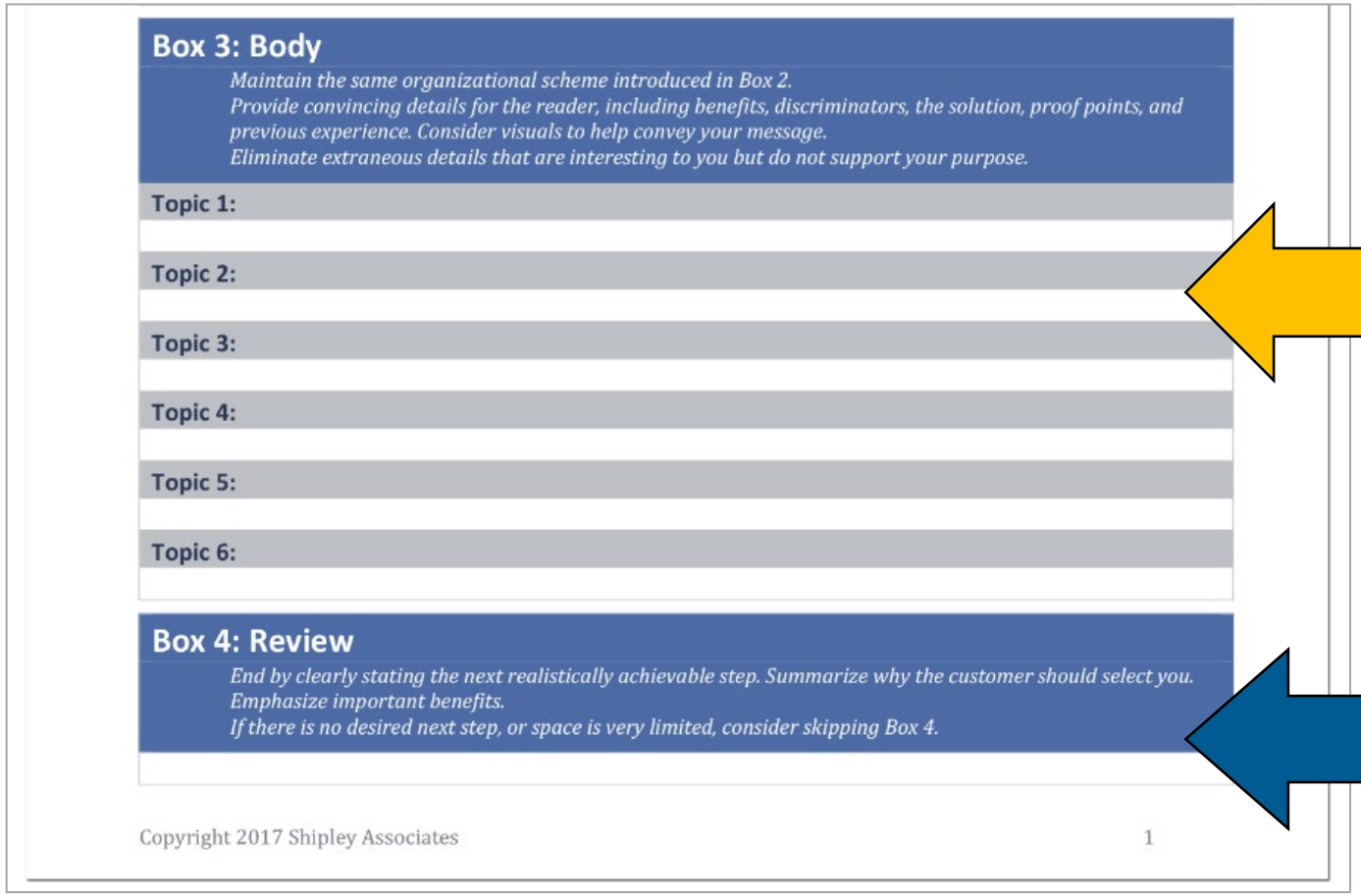
Four-Box Template Simplifies Organization



Box 3: Body

Maintain the same organizational scheme introduced in Box 2.
Provide convincing details for the reader, including benefits, discriminators, the solution, proof points, and previous experience. Consider visuals to help convey your message.
Eliminate extraneous details that are interesting to you but do not support your purpose.

Topic 1:

Topic 2:

Topic 3:

Topic 4:

Topic 5:

Topic 6:

Box 4: Review

End by clearly stating the next realistically achievable step. Summarize why the customer should select you. Emphasize important benefits.
If there is no desired next step, or space is very limited, consider skipping Box 4.

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Sign posts:

- Topic=Requirement (issue A, B, C)
- Solution
- Benefit
- Proof
- Visual

Close with power…

- Here's what we told you
- Benefits/discriminators/features
- Last thing you want them to know about you and your offer

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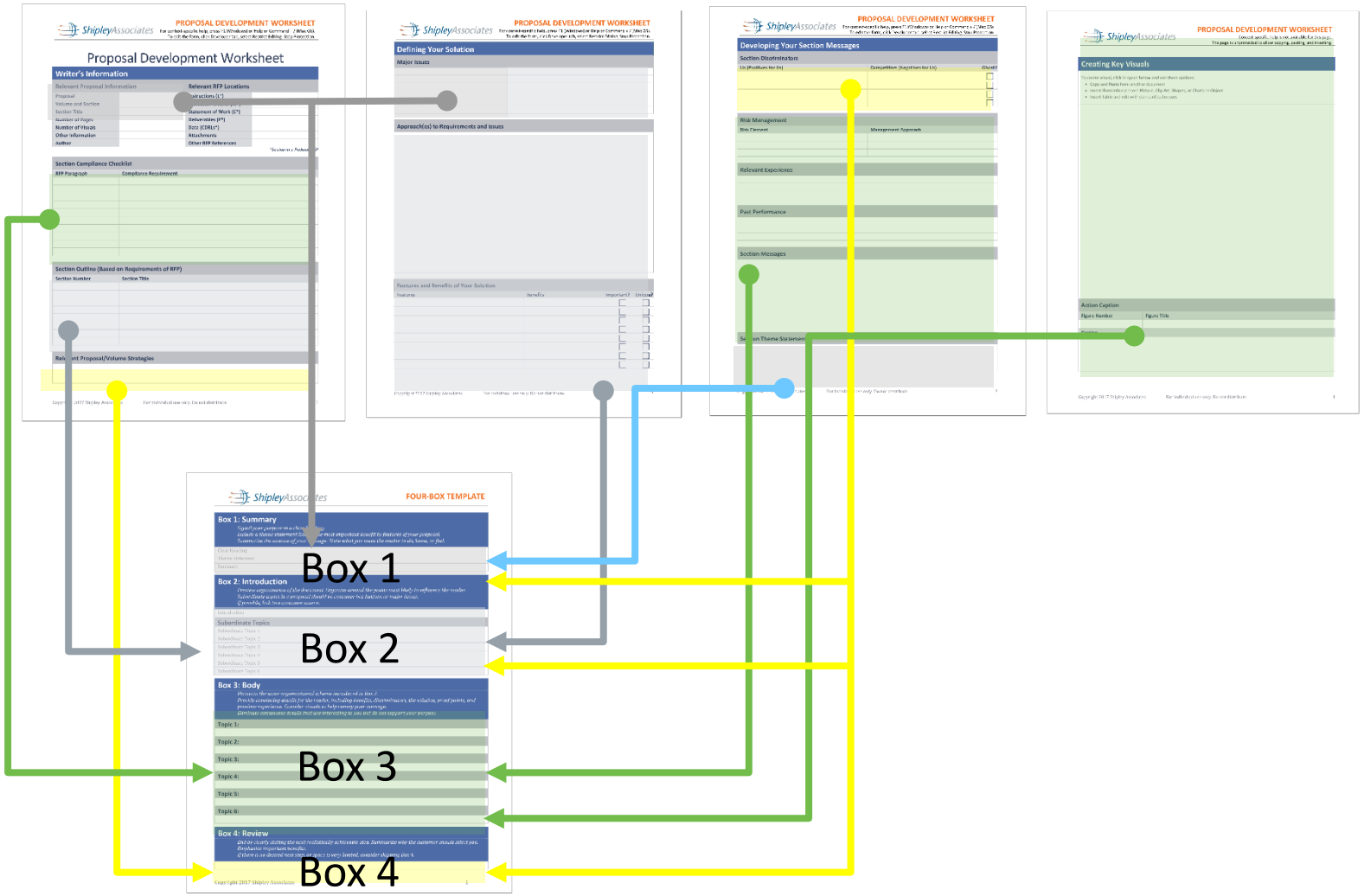
Mapping the PDW to the Proposal Section Organizer

Page 126

PDW

Four-box Organizer



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15 Ways to Destroy Readability

Use weak verbs:

01

Jack and Jill went up the hill to get a pail of water.

Use Unfamiliar words:

02

Jack and Jill climbed up the hill to fetch a ewer of water.

Put introductory phrases at the beginning to push the subject back:

03

To fetch a pail of water, Jack and Jill climbed up the hill.

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15 Ways to Destroy Readability

Put the action at the end of the sentence:

04 Jack and Jill, to fetch a pail of water, climbed up the hill.

Keep modifiers as far as possible from the words they modify:

05 Jack and Jill climbed to fetch a pail of water up the hill.

Use passive voice:

06 The hill was climbed by Jack and Jill so that a pail of water could be fetched.

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15 Ways to Destroy Readability

Put the doer at the end of the sentence:

07 To fetch a pail of water, the hill was climbed by Jack and Jill.

Introduce false subjects:

08 It was Jack and Jill that climbed up the hill to fetch a pail of water.

Pile on the gobbledygook (fluff):

09 Jack and Jill ascended the acclivity to retrieve a vessel of Adam's ale.

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15 Ways to Destroy Readability

Turn verbs into nouns:

10

Jack and Jill did the hill climb for purpose of water retrieval.

Use unnecessary technical jargon:

11

Jack and Jill traversed the gradient to fetch an alembic vessel of H20.

Add wordy phrases (fluff):

12

Jack, in the company of Jill, climbed their way up the hill for the purpose of fetching water in the approximate amount of a pail's full.

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15 Ways to Destroy Readability

Multiple redundant words:

13

Both Jack and Jill climbed all the way up to the top of the hill's summit to fetch a pail filled to its capacity with water.

Throw in clichés indiscriminately:

14

Jack and Jill, who need no introduction, climbed up the hill by leaps and bounds to fetch through their good offices a pail of water by hook or by crook.

String lots of nouns together to form the subject:

15

The Jack and Jill water retrieval hill ascent was achieved.

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Use Ghosting to Counter Competitors

Competitor's Weaknesses:	You Stress:
Start-up teaming partner	Stable partners
Hands-off oversight	Onsite project management
High turnover	Employee retention
Failed implementations	Successful transition
Limited retail clients	Retail strength
No local presence	In-country presence

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Ode to the Spell Checker

Eyes helps one spell correctly, but
a mistake will see it not.

Wrote by your side is sometimes
mistaken.

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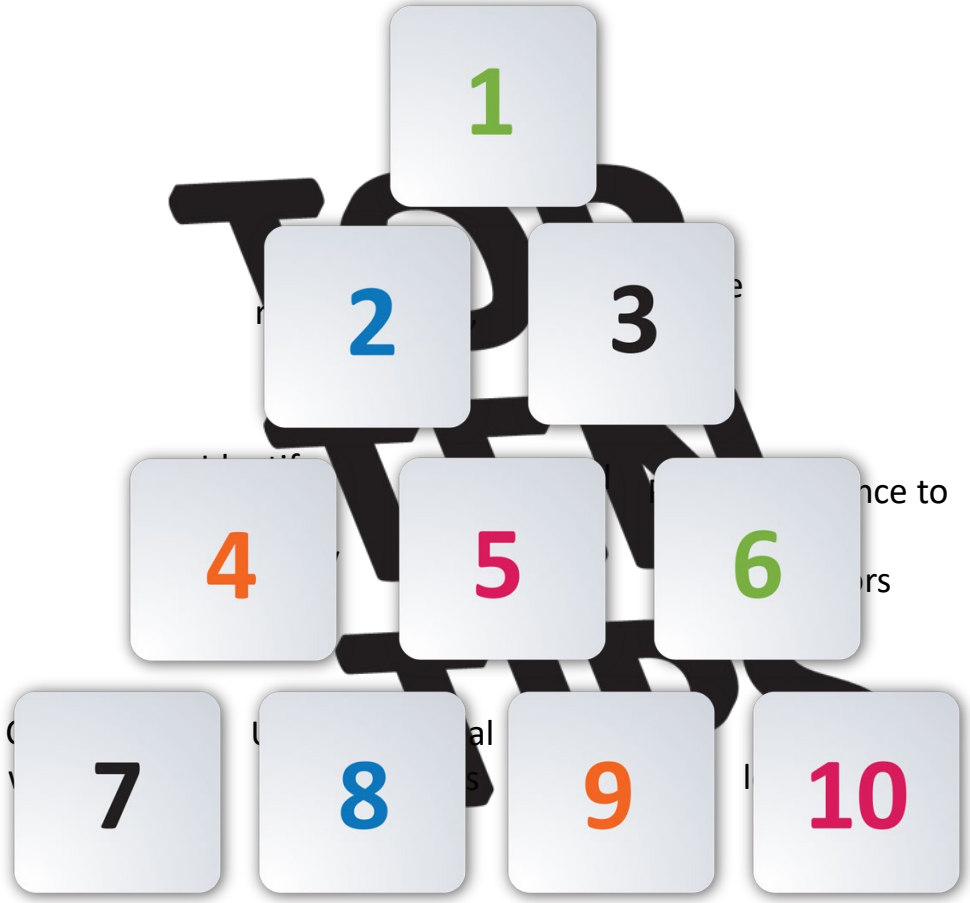
Top 10 Tips from Industry Leaders



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